

Brian W. Payne

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Business Operations & Strategy • Operational Excellence • Organizational Transformation • Customer Experience • Technology & AI

Operations and technology leader who builds new organizational capabilities by aligning people, processes, technology, and data to improve execution and customer outcomes. Experience spans operational transformation, customer experience, organizational design, platform modernization, and cross-functional leadership across consumer technology, media, sports, travel, retail, and membership businesses.

EXPERIENCE

Sulcata Partners

New York, NY / Yardley, PA

Consulting firm focused on operations, technology, customer experience, and organizational improvement.

Operations & Technology Consultant

2025 - present

Advise startups, professional sports organizations, and retail businesses on operations, technology, AI adoption, customer experience, and organizational effectiveness.

- Developed product strategy, technology roadmap, staffing model, and 18-month operating plan for an early-stage technology company supporting fundraising and growth.
- Designed enterprise data, analytics, scouting, and AI/RAG capabilities supporting baseball operations and executive decision-making for professional baseball organizations.
- Led retail transformation initiatives spanning CRM, ecommerce, customer analytics, pricing, fulfillment, AI workflows, and operational redesign.
- Founded and operate an independent service business, applying CRM, analytics, customer acquisition, AI, and operational disciplines in a live business environment.

Chief

New York, NY

Private membership network and digital platform serving senior women executives.

Senior Director of Engineering | Business Transformation

2023 - 2024

Joined Chief during a period of significant organizational transformation following years of rapid growth. Partnered with executive leadership to simplify the operating model, strengthen cross-functional execution, and help the organization deliver more with fewer resources while maintaining member experience and platform reliability.

- **Redesigned the engineering operating model** by reorganizing 40+ engineers into cross-functional product teams, improving ownership, collaboration, and delivery consistency across engineering, product, and business.
- **Entrusted with expanded organizational leadership** following an executive transition, providing continuity across the engineering organization while also overseeing Product during multiple organizational restructurings.
- **Improved organizational effectiveness** by introducing modern engineering workflows, AI-assisted development practices, and stronger operational visibility, enabling teams to deliver more consistently with significantly reduced resources.

FreedomPay

Philadelphia, PA

Global commerce platform providing payment technology and services to enterprise merchants.

Director of Engineering | Operational Excellence

2022 - 2023

Joined FreedomPay to improve the effectiveness of engineering organizations supporting customer-facing payment platforms. Worked with engineering leadership to improve operational execution, increase organizational transparency, strengthen cross-functional collaboration, and create stronger connections between engineering teams and customer needs.

- **Reduced production incidents by approximately 60%** by improving engineering quality, delivery practices, and QA automation while increasing platform reliability.

- **Improved delivery predictability and organizational visibility** by introducing stronger planning, communication, and operational metrics across multiple engineering teams.
- **Brought engineering closer to customer needs** by reducing organizational barriers between technical teams, product stakeholders, and the business, improving collaboration, organizational effectiveness, and execution.

Pro Football Focus

Cincinnati, OH / NYC, NY

Sports analytics and digital products company serving professional football teams, media, and consumers.

VP Engineering, Consumer Products | Product Strategy

2021 - 2022

Recruited by the CEO to establish the company's first consumer engineering organization and help transform a sports analytics business into a consumer product company.

- Built and led the company's first Consumer Engineering organization responsible for new digital consumer experiences.
- Introduced customer discovery, MVP development, experimentation, and cross-functional Product–Engineering collaboration to establish a modern consumer product operating model.
- Established the organizational foundation for consumer product development before executive leadership changes redirected company priorities.

Major League Baseball

New York, NY

Professional sports league operating Major League Baseball's digital products, media, streaming, ticketing, and fan experiences.

Director of Engineering | Digital Platforms & Strategy

2018 – 2021

Hired to strengthen collaboration between Product and Engineering while improving MLB's ability to understand customer behavior across its digital products through standardized platforms, experimentation, and analytics.

- Standardized customer measurement and experimentation capabilities to improve product decision making across MLB's digital ecosystem.
- Partnered across Product, Engineering, and Analytics to strengthen customer learning and iterative product development.
- Established shared platforms that enabled teams to move faster while making more data-informed decisions.

Priceline

New York, NY

Leading online travel platform for hotels, flights, rental cars, and vacation packages.

Director, Web & Mobile | Digital Product Strategy

2015– 2018

Hired as Priceline's first Director of Engineering to help scale a rapidly growing engineering organization by redesigning team structures, operating models, and Product–Engineering collaboration.

- Reorganized engineering into cross-functional, product-aligned teams while introducing Agile operating models and delivery practices that improved collaboration and execution.
- **Managed Priceline's User Research function**, directing team operations, research prioritization, and budget while integrating customer insights into Product and Engineering decision-making.
- Led organizational change across managers and engineering teams, strengthening cross-functional collaboration between Product, Engineering, Design, and User Research.
- Expanded customer research and feedback capabilities, helping establish a more evidence-based product development process.

EARLY CAREER

eBay Marketplace, San Jose, CA — Engineering Manager, Buyer Experience - Built and led engineering within eBay's Buyer Experience organization, establishing rapid-prototyping capabilities and strengthening collaboration across Design, Research, Product, and Engineering. **2011 - 2015**

GSI Commerce, King of Prussia, PA — Technical Developer Lead - Progressed from developer to team lead, ultimately leading engineering delivery for major ecommerce clients including Ralph Lauren. **2002 - 2010**

EXECUTIVE CAPABILITIES

Business Operations & Transformation • Technology Strategy & AI • Customer Experience & Digital Product • Cross-Functional Leadership & Organizational Change

TECHNICAL FOUNDATION

Modern cloud architectures (AWS, GCP), web & mobile platforms, APIs, React, Node.js, TypeScript, GraphQL, DevOps, CI/CD, experimentation platforms, customer analytics, operational reliability, and AI-assisted software development.

EDUCATION

Temple University, Accounting

Philadelphia, PA

Chubb Institute, Software Development

Springfield, PA

INTERESTS

Cycling & Bike Touring • Guitar • Genealogy